PHYS4071

Big Bang Cosmology & Inflation

Course Notes

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Introduction

About These Notes

These notes accompany the PHYS4071 Big Bang Cosmology & Inflation course. They are intended as a self-contained supplement to the lectures, providing both conceptual grounding and mathematical rigour at a level appropriate for readers with a background in special relativity, basic linear algebra, and basic calculus.

The material covers different cosmological topics, including but not limited to the Friedmann equations, and the energy budget of the ΛCDM model. Each topic is structured to serve different learning objectives—from building physical intuition to solving examination-style problems and exploring advanced derivations.

These notes do not replace lecture slides or the recommended textbooks. They are best used alongside them as a structured study companion.

If you find any errors or have suggestions for improvement, please feel free to contact me at `yhip@connect.ust.hk`.

Document Conventions

Block Components

Each topic is presented using a consistent **5-component block structure** designed to support multiple learning styles:

Physics Intuition

Purpose: Builds conceptual understanding through plain language explanations.
This section provides the *motivation* behind the physics concept, explores its *historical development*, and offers *intuitive explanations* that help you grasp what the theory is really about before diving into equations.

Use this when: You're first encountering a new concept or need to refresh the "big picture" before tackling mathematics.

Theory

Purpose: Provides rigorous mathematical treatment of the concept. Here you'll find detailed *derivations*, *fundamental assumptions*, key *equations*, and connections between *mathematics and physical intuition*. This is the technical foundation required for exams and deeper problem-solving.

Use this when: You need to understand how to apply formulas, prepare for exams, or work through problems rigorously.

Question Examples

Purpose: Demonstrates practical application through worked problems.
Each question example mimics exam-style problems and includes complete *solution walkthroughs*. These help you bridge the gap between theory and problem-solving, and expose common pitfalls.

Use this when: Practicing problem-solving, preparing for assessments, or checking if you can apply the formulas correctly.

Foundation

Purpose: Supplies background knowledge and detailed proof steps that underpin the main content.
This section presents *prerequisite mathematics or physics*, *step-by-step derivations* that are too detailed to include in the Theory block, and *intermediate results* needed for a thorough understanding. Reading this is optional for the exam but essential for genuine mastery.

Use this when: A derivation in Theory feels too abrupt, you want to verify an intermediate step, or you need to solidify prerequisite concepts.

Extra

Purpose: Provides supplementary material that extends *beyond* the course syllabus.
This section offers *interesting asides*, *historical context*, *connections to current research*, and citations to deeper references. The content here is intentionally out-of-scope for the course examination but enriches the broader picture of each topic.

Use this when: You're curious to explore beyond the syllabus, or when a topic connects to your personal research interests.

Suggested Reading Paths:

1. **Exam Preparation:** *Physics Intuition* → *Theory* → *Question Examples*
2. **Deep Learning:** *Physics Intuition* → *Foundation* → *Theory* → *Question Examples* → *Extra*
3. **Quick Review:** *Theory* → *Question Examples*

Special Annotations

In addition to the five block components above, two inline annotations appear throughout the text to flag specific types of information:

IMPORTANT NOTE

Purpose: Alerts you to a result, condition, or sign convention that is easy to get wrong or is frequently tested.
An Important Note signals a *common misconception*, a *critical sign*, a *non-obvious condition* (e.g. a constraint that must hold for an equation to be valid), or an *exam trap* worth memorising explicitly.

Treat these as mandatory reading regardless of which reading path you follow.

REMARK

Purpose: Highlights a useful observation, connection, or naming convention.
A Remark draws attention to a *conceptual link* between results, an *elegant reformulation*, a *naming convention* (e.g. why a quantity carries its particular name), or a *minor but clarifying point* that does not rise to the level of an Important Note.

Use this when: Looking for a deeper understanding of why an equation takes the form it does, or for useful mnemonics.

Mathematical Conventions

The following conventions are used throughout these notes:

Metric signature. We adopt the *mostly-plus* (or "$(-,+,+,+)$") signature:

$$g_{\mu\nu} = \mathrm{diag}(-1,\ +1,\ +1,\ +1).$$

Important Note

Many general-relativity textbooks use the opposite, *mostly-minus* $(+,-,-,-)$ signature. The two conventions differ by an overall sign in the Ricci scalar and stress-energy trace. Always check the signature convention when comparing formulae across sources.

Natural units. In sections on particle physics or early-universe thermodynamics, we may set $c = \hbar = k_B = 1$. Quantities are then expressed in powers of eV (or GeV). Explicit c and $\hbar$ factors are restored when numerical values are quoted in SI units.

Key symbols.

Symbol	Meaning	Typical units
H_0	Hubble constant today	$\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$
h	Dimensionless Hubble: $H_0 = 100h$	—
Ω_i	Density parameter for species i	—
$a(t)$	Scale factor ($a_0 = 1$ today)	—
z	Cosmological redshift	—
ρ_{crit}	Critical density	$\mathrm{kg\,m^{-3}}$

Remark

The convention $a_0 \equiv a(t_0) = 1$ is standard and simplifies many formulae, e.g. $1 + z = 1/a(t_e)$. Some older texts normalise a differently; always check the definition when reading the literature.

CHAPTER 1

Fundamentals (lecture 1-2)

1.1 Natural Units

PHYSICS INTUITION

In SI units, we treat time, length, mass, and energy as distinct physical quantities with different dimensions and units.

To make calculations more convenient, we introduce natural units to connect these quantities via fundamental constants, so that we can express everything in terms of a single unit and same type of dimension (i.e. energy).

THEORY

In natural units, we set $c = \hbar = k_B = 1$.
When $c = 1$, mass and energy are measured in the same units and dimension in terms of E^1 by $E = mc^2 = m$.

Question Example 1.1: Dimension of Gravitational Constant

What is the dimension of the gravitational constant G in natural units?

Solution. We know that $F = G\frac{m_1 m_2}{r^2}$ and $F = ma$.
We get dimension of a is E^1 by $a = v/t = x/t^2 = \frac{E^{-1}}{E^{-1} \cdot E^{-1}} = E^1$.
Then we get dimension of F is E^2 by $F = ma = E^1 \cdot E^1 = E^2$.
Finally, we get dimension of G is E^{-2} by $G = \frac{Fr^2}{m_1 m_2} = E^2 \cdot E^{-2}/(E^1 \cdot E^1) = E^{-2}$.

In general, we define the dimension of a quantity directly in terms of n if its dimension is E^n for simplicity. Below are some useful conversion factors between SI and natural units:

Quantity	Related equation	SI dimension	Natural unit
Energy	$E = mc^2$	$\mathrm{kg\,m^2\,s^{-2}}$	1
Mass	$m = E/c^2$	kg	1
Frequency	$\nu = E/h$	Hz	1
Time	$t = 1/\nu$	s	-1
Space	$x = ct$	m	-1
Temperature	$T = E/k_B$	K	1
Velocity	$v = x/t$	$\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$	0
Momentum	$p = E/c$	$\mathrm{kg\,m\,s^{-1}}$	1
Angular Velocity	$\omega = rv$	$\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$	-1
Angular Momentum	$L = \frac{1}{2}mv\omega$	$\mathrm{kg\,m^2\,s^{-1}}$	0
Luminosity	$\mathcal{L} = E/t$	W	2
Force	$F = p/t$	N	2
Pressure	$P = F/A$	Pa	2
Mass Density	$\rho = m/V$	$\mathrm{kg\,m^{-3}}$	4
Energy Density	$\rho = E/V$	$\mathrm{J\,m^{-3}}$	4
Gravitational Constant	$G = Fr^2/m_1m_2$	$\mathrm{m^3\,kg^{-1}\,s^{-2}}$	-2
Redshift	$z = \lambda_0/\lambda_e - 1$	—	0
Cosmological Scale Factor	$a(t) = 1/(1+z)$	—	0
Hubble Parameter	$H = \dot{a}/a$	$\mathrm{s^{-1}}$	1

Remark

In the Heaviside-Lorentz system of natural units, we also set $\epsilon_0 = \mu_0 = 1$. Which one can hence get the dimension of charge q is 0.

1.2 4-Vectors and Tensors

1.2.1 4-Vectors

FOUNDATION

In special relativity, we treat the time and space coordinates on equal footing as a 4-vector $x^\mu = (t, x, y, z) = (x^0, x^1, x^2, x^3)$. or in other words, we used the 4-vector to combine the time and space coordinates together.

THEORY

By using the 4-vector, we can write the Lorentz transformation in-terms of the Lorentz transformation matrix and the 4-vector:
WLOG, we can consider a boost in the x-direction with velocity v,

$$\begin{pmatrix} t' \\ x' \\ y' \\ z' \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} \gamma & -\gamma\beta & 0 & 0 \\ -\gamma\beta & \gamma & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} t \\ x \\ y \\ z \end{pmatrix},$$

where $\gamma = 1/\sqrt{1-v^2}$ is the Lorentz factor, and $\beta = v/c$ is the velocity in units of c ($\beta = v$ in natural units).

1.2.2 Einstein Summation Convention

PHYSICS INTUITION

Each time when we are doing the 4-vectors operations like the Lorentz transformation, we are doing the summation of the products of the components of the 4-vectors and the Lorentz transformation matrix.

It can be very tedious to write down the summation every time, so we want a more compact notation to represent the summation.

THEORY

Using the example of the Lorentz transformation above, if we want to do the transformation in traditional way, we have to write down the summation explicitly:

$$x^{\mu'} = \Sigma_{\nu=0}^{3} \Lambda^\mu{}_\nu x^\nu.$$

By using the Einstein summation convention, we can simply write down the transformation as:

$$x^{\mu'} = \Lambda^\mu{}_\nu x^\nu.$$

1.2.3 Metric Tensor

Physics Intuition

In a non-Euclidean space, such as the Minkowski spacetime in special relativity, the distance between two points is not simply what we seen in our eyes.
The spacetime interval between two events(or points) is no longer measured by the Pythagorean theorem, so we need to use another ruler to measure it.

In general, we used a metric tensor as the ruler to measure the distance of 2 point in a specific spacetime.

Theory

In traditional Euclidean space, the metric tensor is simply the identity matrix, so the distance between two points is given by the Pythagorean theorem:

$$ds^2 = \begin{pmatrix} dx & dy & dz \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} dx \\ dy \\ dz \end{pmatrix} = dx^2 + dy^2 + dz^2.$$

In Minkowski spacetime, the metric tensor is given by:

$$g_{\mu\nu} = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix},$$

so the spacetime interval is given by:

$$ds^2 = g_{\mu\nu} dx^\mu dx^\nu = -dt^2 + dx^2 + dy^2 + dz^2$$

or in other words, the spacetime interval is calculated by the dot product of the 4-vector with itself by using the metric tensor as the dot product operator:

Theory

$$A \cdot B = g_{\mu\nu} A^\mu B^\nu = \begin{pmatrix} A^0 & A^1 & A^2 & A^3 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} g_{00} & g_{01} & g_{02} & g_{03} \\ g_{10} & g_{11} & g_{12} & g_{13} \\ g_{20} & g_{21} & g_{22} & g_{23} \\ g_{30} & g_{31} & g_{32} & g_{33} \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} B^0 \\ B^1 \\ B^2 \\ B^3 \end{pmatrix}$$

1.2.4 Tensors

Physics Intuition

Now you may wonder, why sometimes the index is up, and sometimes it is down? Is there any difference between them?
The answer is yes, they are different.

The upper index represents a **contravariant** component, while the lower index represents a **covariant** component.
By the combination of the **contravariant** and **convariant** components, we can construct a more general mathematical object called a **tensor**.

Foundation

In tensor calculus and differential geometry, the position of an index (upper or lower) indicates how the component of the tensor transforms when you change the coordinate system.

Direct Mapping:

- **Upper Index** (μ in V^μ): Represents a **Contravariant** component.
- **Lower Index** (μ in V_μ): Represents a **Covariant** component.

Transformation Rules:
The terms *contravariant* and *covariant* describe how components change relative to **basis vectors** when switching coordinates (e.g., Cartesian to Polar, or meters to centimeters).

Contravariant (Upper Index):

- **Symbol:** V^μ
- **Transformation:** Transforms **inversely** (against) the basis vectors.
- **Law:** $V'^\mu = \dfrac{\partial x'^\mu}{\partial x^\nu} V^\nu$
- **Intuition:** If your ruler shrinks (smaller basis vectors), the numerical value must grow to describe the same physical length. Example: 1 m = 100 cm.

Covariant (Lower Index):

- **Symbol:** V_μ
- **Transformation:** Transforms **in the same way** (with) the basis vectors.

- **Law:** $V'_\mu = \dfrac{\partial x^\nu}{\partial x'^\mu} V_\nu$

- **Intuition:** Like a gradient (slope). If the ruler shrinks, the slope per unit distance also shrinks.

Geometric Interpretation:

- **Contravariant Vectors** (V^μ): Standard "arrows" tangent to a curve, living in the **Tangent Space**.

- **Covariant Vectors** (V_μ): Called **Dual Vectors** or **One-Forms**. They are functions that map vectors to scalars and live in the **Cotangent Space**. Geometrically visualized as stacked parallel surfaces pierced by vectors.

Einstein Summation Convention:
The distinction is critical, repeated indices (one upper, one lower) indicate summation. Only these are coordinate-invariant scalars.

- **Valid:** $S = A^\mu B_\mu \quad \Rightarrow$ scalar invariant
- **Invalid:** $A^\mu B^\mu$ or $A_\mu B_\mu \quad \Rightarrow$ not coordinate-invariant (not summation)

Summary Table

Property	Contravariant	Covariant
Index Position	Upper ($^\mu$)	Lower ($_\mu$)
Notation	V^μ	V_μ
Also Called	Vector	Dual Vector / One-Form
Transformation	Opposite to basis	Same as basis
Example	Displacement, Velocity	Gradient
Metric Operation	Lowered by $g_{\mu\nu}$	Raised by $g^{\mu\nu}$

THEORY

Raising and Lowering Indices:
With the **Metric Tensor** ($g_{\mu\nu}$), you can convert between contravariant and covariant components:

- **Lowering:** $V_\mu = g_{\mu\nu} V^\nu$ (contravariant $\to$ covariant)
- **Raising:** $V^\mu = g^{\mu\nu} V_\nu$ (covariant $\to$ contravariant)

And the contravariant(inverse) metric $g^{\mu\nu}$ is the inverse of the covariant metric $g_{\mu\nu}$, so we have:

Theory

$$g^{\mu\nu} g_{\nu\sigma} = \delta^{\mu}{}_{\sigma},$$

where $\delta^{\mu}{}_{\sigma}$ is the Kronecker delta, which is 1 if $\mu = \sigma$ and 0 otherwise.

As a results, we can further simplified the operations like the dot product and trace:

Theory

$$A \cdot B = g_{\mu\nu} A^{\mu} B^{\nu} = A_{\nu} B^{\nu} = A^{\mu} B_{\mu}$$
$$T = g^{\mu\nu} T_{\mu\nu} = g_{\mu\nu} T^{\mu\nu} = T^{\nu}{}_{\nu} = T_{\mu}{}^{\mu}$$

Question Example 1.2: Trace of Spherical Minkowski Metric

Calculate the trace of the spherical Minkowski metric $g_{\mu\nu} = \mathrm{diag}(-1, 1, r^2, r^2 \sin^2\theta)$.

Solution. We need to first calculate the inverse metric $g^{\mu\nu}$, which is given by:

$$g^{\mu\nu} = g_{\mu\nu}^{-1} = \mathrm{diag}(-1, 1, r^{-2}, r^{-2} \sin^{-2}\theta).$$

Then we can calculate the trace:

$$T = g^{\mu\nu} g_{\mu\nu} = (-1)(-1) + (1)(1) + (r^{-2})(r^2) + (r^{-2} \sin^{-2}\theta)(r^2 \sin^2\theta) = 4.$$

Important Note

In flat Euclidean space with Cartesian coordinates, $g_{\mu\nu} = \delta_{\mu\nu}$ (identity), so $V^{\mu} = V_{\mu}$ numerically.

However, for other spacetimes (e.g., Minkowski, curved), the metric is not the identity, and V^{μ} and V_{μ} can differ significantly. The distinction becomes crucial in General Relativity and curvilinear coordinates. To be safe, treat them as different objects and always check the metric when raising/lowering indices.

EXTRA

The tensor T is said to be of type (p,q) if it has:

- p: The number of contravariant indices(upper indices)
- q: The number of convariant indices(lower indices)

Tensor with different types cannot be added together or equal to each other, in such a meaning, you can think of the type of a tensor as its "dimension" in the space of tensors, and only tensors with the same type can be compared or combined.

Tensor Rank: The total rank of a Tensor T is p + q (let said p + q = n), and we will said it is a rank-n-Tensor

Note that the rank of a tensor is not the same as linear algebra rank of a matrix. The rank of a tensor is the total number of indices, while the linear algebra rank is the maximum number of linearly independent rows or columns in a matrix. Thats mean a rank-2 tensor can have a linear algebra rank of 0, 1, or 2 depending on its components.

Tensor Type	p	q	Rank	Example
(0,0)	0	0	0	Scalar (e.g., Temperature)
(1,0)	1	0	1	Contravariant Vector (e.g., Displacement V^μ)
(0,1)	0	1	1	Covariant Vector (e.g., Gradient V_μ)
(1,1)	1	1	2	Mixed Tensor (e.g., Linear Transformation $\Lambda^\mu{}_\nu$)
(2,0)	2	0	2	Contravariant Tensor (e.g., Inverse Metric $g^{\mu\nu}$)
(0,2)	0	2	2	Covariant Tensor (e.g., Metric Tensor $g_{\mu\nu}$)
(1,3)	1	3	4	Riemann Curvature ($R^\rho_{\sigma\mu\nu}$)

1.2.5 Energy-Momentum Tensor

Physics Intuition

In Newtonian mechanics, we thought mass is the source of gravity, but in relativity, we found that mass is a form of energy($E = mc^2$), so energy must also be a source of gravity.
Further, momentum is also a form of energy($E^2 = p^2c^2 + m^2c^4$), so momentum must also be a source of gravity.

The energy-momentum tensor expand the concept of a scalar energy density to a 4x4 matrix that track of all "components" in a region of spacetime that contributes to gravity.

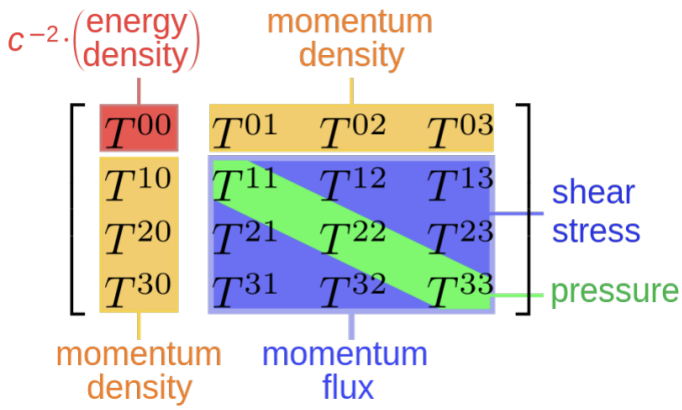

Figure 1.1: The components of the energy-momentum tensor $T^{\mu\nu}$ and their physical interpretations.

Foundation

Interpretation of Components:
For a component $T^{\mu\nu}$ of the energy-momentum tensor, it represents the flux of the μ-th component of the 4-momentum across a volume of constant ν-th coordinate.

(1) Time-Energy Component: T^{00} (Top-Left Corner)

- **What it is:** Energy density — the amount of energy per unit volume.
- **Includes:** Mass (via $E = mc^2$), heat, light, and chemical energy.
- **Gravitational role:** Primary source of gravity for everyday objects (e.g., the Earth).

(2) Energy Flux Components: T^{01}, T^{02}, T^{03} (Top Row)

- **What they measure:** Energy flowing through surfaces in the x-, y-, and z-directions.
- **Physical picture:** A beam of light passing through the volume carries energy in a direction.
- **Key insight:** In relativity, energy flux is equivalent to momentum density. Moving energy carries momentum!

(3) Momentum Density Components: T^{10}, T^{20}, T^{30} (Left Column)

- **What they measure:** The amount of momentum stored inside the volume.
- **Surprising fact:** These values are typically equal to the energy flux components above!
- **Implication:** Energy flow and momentum density are intimately related.

(4) Stress and Pressure Components: T^{11} to T^{33} (Bottom-Right 3×3 Grid)

- **Physical meaning:** Forces and stresses acting within the material.
- **Diagonal terms** (T^{11}, T^{22}, T^{33}): **Pressure**
  - Gas molecules bouncing off the walls of the volume exert pressure.
  - **Remarkable fact:** Pressure creates gravity!
  - A box of hot gas (high pressure) has slightly more gravitational mass than cold gas with the same rest mass, because pressure contributes to the stress-energy tensor.
- **Off-diagonal terms** (T^{12}, T^{23}, etc.): **Shear Stress**
  - Internal friction between different parts of the material.
  - Analogy: Sliding the top half of a deck of cards sideways relative to the bottom.

FOUNDATION

The energy-momentum tensor has 2 important properties:

(1) Symmetry: $T^{\mu\nu} = T^{\nu\mu}$

- Reason 1: Energy flux and momentum density are equal, so $T^{0i} = T^{i0}$.
- Reason 2: The stress tensor (bottom-right 3×3) is symmetric due to the conservation of angular momentum. If there were a torque, it would cause the material to rotate infinitely fast, which would violate the conservation of angular momentum.

(2) Conservation: $\partial_\mu T^{\mu\nu} = 0$

imagine a small box in space-time. The conservation law states that the amount of energy-momentum flowing into the box along the μ-th direction must equal the amount flowing out along the ν-th direction. This ensures that energy and momentum are conserved locally.

IMPORTANT NOTE

The energy-momentum tensor is a symmetric so there are only 10 independent components at a single point in spacetime.

If we further consider the conservation law, we can reduce the number of degree of freedom to 6, as it provides 4 additional constraints on the components of the energy-momentum tensor.

(i.e. 10 independent components, with 4 constraints from conservation, leaves 6 degrees of freedom.)

REMARK

In fact, for different type of fluids, the can have different number of degree of freedom, 6 is just the upper bound for a general fluid. For example, a perfect fluid has only 5 degree of freedom, which are the energy density(1) and pressure(1) and velocity(3), as it is isotropic and has no shear stress.

Theory

For frictionless perfect fluid, the energy-momentum tensor can be written as:

$$T^{\mu\nu} = (\rho + P)u^\mu u^\nu + Pg^{\mu\nu},$$

where ρ is the energy density, P is the pressure, and u^μ is the 4-velocity of the fluid.
WLOG, we can consider a comoving frame where the fluid is at rest, so $u^\mu = (1, 0, 0, 0)$, then we can simplify the energy-momentum tensor to:

$$T^{\mu\nu} = \begin{pmatrix} \rho & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & P & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & P & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & P \end{pmatrix}$$

The perfect fluid is a good approximation for many astrophysical and cosmological systems, such as stars, galaxies, and the large-scale structure of the universe. As it is isotropic and has no shear stress, it can be used to model the behavior of matter in these systems without having to consider the complexities of viscosity and heat conduction.

1.3 Einstein Field Equations

1.4 Cosmological Principle

The cosmological principle is a fundamental assumption in cosmology that states that the universe is homogeneous and isotropic on large scales. This means that the universe looks the same in all directions (isotropic) and has the same properties at every point (homogeneous) when viewed on sufficiently large scales.

Extra

The cosmic Microwave Background (CMB) radiation provides strong evidence for the cosmological principle, as it is observed to be nearly uniform in all directions, with only tiny fluctuations at the level of one part in 100,000.

CHAPTER 2

Hubble's Law and Cosmological Redshift (lecture 3-4)

2.1 Robertson-Walker Metric

2.1.1 Metric for a Homogeneous and Isotropic Universe

PHYSICS INTUITION

In general relativity, the geometry of spacetime can be curved.
Therefore, we need another metric instead of the Minkowski metric to describe the geometry of the universe.
The Robertson-Walker metric was hence introduced to describe a homogeneous and isotropic universe in large scales.

THEORY

By the cosmological principle, the universe is homogeneous and isotropic on large scales.
In mathematics, there are only three possible spatial geometries that satisfy these conditions, defined by the constant curvature k:

- $k = 0$: flat geometry (Euclidean space)
- $k > 0$: closed geometry (spherical space)
- $k < 0$: open geometry (hyperbolic space)

And we need to write the line element dl^2 for such a spacetime.
Note that the cosmological principle only states that the universe is homogeneous and isotropic, but it does not forbid the universe to expand or contract.
Therefore, we need to introduce a time-dependent scale factor $a(t)$ to describe the expansion of the universe.

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + a^2(t)dl^2$$

To fullfill the isotropy condition, we will use spherical coordinates to write the spatial line element dl^2:

$$dl^2 = g_{rr}dr^2 + g_{\theta\theta}d\theta^2 + g_{\phi\phi}d\phi^2$$

FOUNDATION

you may ask why we dont need to consider the cross terms like $g_{r\theta}drd\theta$ in the line element.

The reason is that the cross terms would break the isotropy of the universe. For example, if we have a cross term like $g_{r\theta}drd\theta$, it would mean that the radial distance between two points in the universe would depend on the direction we are looking at, which would violate the isotropy condition.

Therefore, we can safely ignore the cross terms in the line element when we are considering a homogeneous and isotropic universe.

THEORY

Flat geometry ($k = 0$):
It is trivial to get the line element for flat geometry, which is just the Euclidean space:

$$dl^2 = dr^2 + r^2 d\Omega^2 = dr^2 + r^2(d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta d\phi^2)$$

which $d\Omega^2$ is the line element of a unit sphere(r = 1).
Hence, the metric for a flat universe is:

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + a^2(t)[dr^2 + r^2 d\Omega^2] = -dt^2 + a^2(t)\left[dr^2 + r^2(d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta d\phi^2)\right]$$

However, for the closed and open geometry, the coefficient of $d\Omega^2$ is not r^2, but a function of r.

Closed geometry ($k > 0$):
To get the line element for closed geometry like spherical space, we first consider a 3-sphere embedded in a 4-dimensional Euclidean space, which can be described by the equation:

$$x^2 + y^2 + z^2 + w^2 = R^2$$

where R is the radius of the 3-sphere.
We can then use spherical coordinates to parameterize the 3-sphere:

$$\begin{cases} x = R\sin\chi\sin\theta\cos\phi \\ y = R\sin\chi\sin\theta\sin\phi \\ z = R\sin\chi\cos\theta \\ w = R\cos\chi \end{cases}$$

where χ is the radial coordinate that ranges from 0 to π.
And we can get the metric components:

$$\begin{cases} g_{\chi\chi} = \frac{\partial}{\partial\chi}(x,y,z,w)\cdot\frac{\partial}{\partial\chi}(x,y,z,w) = R^2 \\ g_{\theta\theta} = \frac{\partial}{\partial\theta}(x,y,z,w)\cdot\frac{\partial}{\partial\theta}(x,y,z,w) = R^2\sin^2\chi \\ g_{\phi\phi} = \frac{\partial}{\partial\phi}(x,y,z,w)\cdot\frac{\partial}{\partial\phi}(x,y,z,w) = R^2\sin^2\chi\sin^2\theta \end{cases}$$

The line element for the 3-sphere can then be derived as:

$$dl^2 = R^2 \left[d\chi^2 + \sin^2\chi (d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta d\phi^2) \right]$$

Hence, the metric for a closed universe is:

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + a^2(t) R^2 \left[d\chi^2 + \sin^2\chi (d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta d\phi^2) \right]$$

Open geometry ($k < 0$):
To get the line element for open geometry like hyperbolic space, we can consider a 3-hyperboloid embedded in a 4-dimensional Minkowski space, which can be described by the equation:

$$-x^2 - y^2 - z^2 + w^2 = R^2$$

where R is the radius of curvature of the hyperbolic space.
We can then use hyperbolic coordinates to parameterize the 3-hyperboloid:

$$\begin{cases} x = R \sinh\chi \sin\theta \cos\phi \\ y = R \sinh\chi \sin\theta \sin\phi \\ z = R \sinh\chi \cos\theta \\ w = R \cosh\chi \end{cases}$$

where χ is the radial coordinate that ranges from 0 to ∞.
And we can get the metric components:

$$\begin{cases} g_{\chi\chi} = \frac{\partial}{\partial\chi}(x,y,z,w) \cdot \frac{\partial}{\partial\chi}(x,y,z,w) = R^2 \\ g_{\theta\theta} = \frac{\partial}{\partial\theta}(x,y,z,w) \cdot \frac{\partial}{\partial\theta}(x,y,z,w) = R^2 \sinh^2\chi \\ g_{\phi\phi} = \frac{\partial}{\partial\phi}(x,y,z,w) \cdot \frac{\partial}{\partial\phi}(x,y,z,w) = R^2 \sinh^2\chi \sin^2\theta \end{cases}$$

The line element for the 3-hyperboloid can then be derived as:

$$dl^2 = R^2 \left[d\chi^2 + \sinh^2\chi (d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta d\phi^2) \right]$$

Hence, the metric for an open universe is:

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + a^2(t) R^2 \left[d\chi^2 + \sinh^2\chi (d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta d\phi^2) \right]$$

2.1.2 Robertson-Walker metric

Physics Intuition

In order to be simplified, we want to make a unified form of the metric for all three types of geometry.

Theory

Unified form:

$$\begin{pmatrix} g_{tt} & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & g_{rr} & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & g_{\theta\theta} & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & g_{\phi\phi} \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & \frac{a^2(t)}{1-kr^2} & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & a^2(t)r^2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & a^2(t)r^2\sin^2\theta \end{pmatrix}$$

where k is the curvature constant that can take values of 0, 1, or -1 for flat, closed, and open geometries, respectively.
And we defined the r:

$$r = \begin{cases} \chi & ,k = 0 \\ \sin\chi & ,k > 0 \\ \sinh\chi & ,k < 0 \end{cases}$$

Foundation

By the substitution of r into the unified metric and letting the unit $R = 1$, you can easily to get the $d\theta^2$ and $d\phi^2$ terms of 3 types of geometries, and get the corresponding dr^2 term by using the chain rule:

$$dr^2 = \begin{cases} d\chi^2 & ,k = 0 \\ \cos^2\chi d\chi^2 & ,k > 0 \\ \cosh^2\chi d\chi^2 & ,k < 0 \end{cases}$$

$$\Rightarrow \frac{dr^2}{1-kr^2} = \begin{cases} d\chi^2 & ,k = 0 \\ d\chi^2 & ,k > 0 \\ d\chi^2 & ,k < 0 \end{cases}$$

And this unified metric is called the **Robertson-Walker metric**, which can be written as:

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + a^2(t)\left[\frac{dr^2}{1-kr^2} + r^2(d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta d\phi^2)\right]$$

Remark

In modern cosmology, we will use Friedmann-Lemaître-Robertson-Walker (FLRW) metric, but they are essentially the same, the FLRW metric derived from the Einstein field equations instead of geometry approach like the Robertson-Walker metric, and is used for explaining the dynamics of the universe, while the Robertson-Walker metric is used for describing the geometry of the universe.

2.1.3 the Scale Factor $a(t)$

Physics Intuition

Now we get the Robertson-Walker metric, and we know that through "time" the scale factor $a(t)$ can change, and the metric can be different at different time, which means the proper distance between two points in the universe can change with time.

But what the "time" here means? Isn't the special relativity tells us that there is no absolute time?
The "time" here is the proper time of comoving observers, which are observers that are at rest with respect to the expansion of the universe.
For comoving observers, the proper time τ is the same as the coordinate time t.

Physics Intuition

As the scale factor $a(t)$ applied on the metric instead of the coordinates difference dr, $d\theta$, and $d\phi$, we can think the measurement of coordinate spatial distance is fixed, but the measurement unit (the ruler itself) is changing with time.

$$\Delta D_{proper} = a(t)\Delta D_{coordinate}$$

For example, if we have 2 points on balloon, we draw the marks on the balloon to measure the distance between the two points, when the balloon is expanding, the number of marks between the two points is fixed, but the distance between each mark is increasing with time, which means the proper distance between the two points is increasing with time.

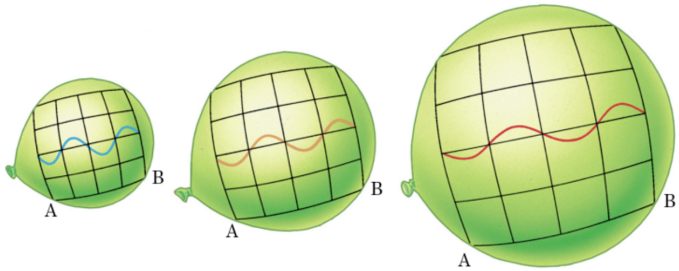

Figure 2.1: The balloon analogy for the expansion of the universe.

REMARK

Although scale factor $a(t)$ can change with time, we assume that the curvature constant k does not change with time, which means the geometry of the universe is fixed.

2.2 Hubble's Law

2.2.1 Redshift and Recession Velocity

CHAPTER 3

Cosmic Evolution (Lecture 5-7)

CHAPTER 4

The Standard Model (Lecture 8)

CHAPTER 5

Thermodynamics and Primordial Soup (Lecture 9-12)

5.1 Statistical Distributions

5.1.1 Energy-Momentum Relation

To calculate the value of various thermodynamic quantities, we need first clarify some basic concepts and notations first for convenience.

In below contents, we will use the $E(p)$ notation to represent the energy of a particle with momentum p and mass m.

FOUNDATION

Recall special relativity, the energy of a particle with mass m and three-momentum p is given by

$$E(\vec{p}) = \sqrt{|\vec{p}|^2c^2 + m^2c^4}.$$

Taken $c = 1$ and $p = |\vec{p}|$, we have $E(p) = \sqrt{p^2 + m^2}$.

In a Non-relativistic limit ($p \ll m$):

$$E(p) = m\sqrt{1 + \frac{p^2}{m^2}} \approx m + \frac{p^2}{2m}.$$

In an Ultra-relativistic limit ($p \gg m$):

$$E(p) \approx p.$$

5.1.2 Chemical Potential

FOUNDATION

μ is the chemical potential, which measures the change in internal energy when a particle is added to the system at constant entropy and volume.

For ideal gases, $\mu \to 0$, and we will assume $\mu = 0$ in below contents unless otherwise specified.

Remark

The chemical potential μ is typically zero for photons and other massless bosons, while it can be non-zero for massive particles depending on the context (e.g., in a gas of electrons).

while for particles and their own anti-particles, $\mu_+ = -\mu_-$.

5.1.3 Thermal Equilibrium Distributions

FOUNDATION

For a state with energy E, and particle number N,

THEORY

In thermal equilibrium, the distribution of particle energies follows specific statistical distributions:

- **Fermi-Dirac distribution** for fermions:

$$f(p) = \frac{1}{e^{(E(p)-\mu)/k_B T} + 1}$$

- **Bose-Einstein distribution** for bosons:

$$f(p) = \frac{1}{e^{(E(p)-\mu)/k_B T} - 1}$$

- **Maxwell-Boltzmann distribution** for classical particles:

$$f(p) = e^{-(E(p)-\mu)/k_B T}$$

In general, the distribution can be written as:

$$f(p) = \frac{1}{e^{(E(p)-\mu)/k_B T} \pm 1},$$

where the $+$ sign is for fermions and the $-$ sign is for bosons.

THEORY

In non-relativistic limit(low temperature & low density), the Fermi-Dirac and Bose-Einstein distributions reduce to the Maxwell-Boltzmann distribution:

$$e^{(E(p)-\mu)/k_B T} \gg 1 \implies f(p) \approx e^{-(E(p)-\mu)/k_B T}$$

5.2 Number Density, Energy Density, and Pressure

5.2.1 Spin Degeneracy Factor

In below contents, we define g as Spin degeneracy factor(spin states), which counts the number of internal degrees of freedom (e.g., spin states) for a particle species.

FOUNDATION

g

EXTRA

The g values for some common particles are:

Particle	symbol	g
Photon	g_γ	2
Electron/Positron	g_e^-, g_e^+	2
Z boson	g_Z	3
Higgs boson	g_H	1

5.2.2 Derivation of the 3 equations

FOUNDATION

THEORY

The number density n, energy density ρ, and pressure P of some particle i are given by:

$$n_i = \frac{g_i}{(2\pi)^3} \int f_i(p)\, d^3p,$$

$$\rho_i = \frac{g_i}{(2\pi)^3} \int E(p) f_i(p)\, d^3p,$$

$$P_i = \frac{g_i}{(2\pi)^3} \int \frac{p^2}{3E(p)} f_i(p)\, d^3p$$

FOUNDATION

By substituting the Fermi-Dirac, Bose-Einstein, or Maxwell-Boltzmann distribution functions into the above integrals, we can derive explicit expressions for n_i, ρ_i, and P_i for different particle species under various conditions (e.g., relativistic vs. non-relativistic limits).

(1) Relativistic Fermions ($E \approx p$):

- Number density: $n_i = \frac{3\zeta(3)}{4\pi^2} g_i T^3$
- Energy density: $\rho_i = \frac{7\pi^2}{120} g_i T^4$
- Pressure: $P_i = \frac{1}{3}\rho_i$

(2) Relativistic Bosons ($E \approx p$):

- Number density: $n_i = \frac{\zeta(3)}{\pi^2} g_i T^3$
- Energy density: $\rho_i = \frac{\pi^2}{30} g_i T^4$
- Pressure: $P_i = \frac{1}{3}\rho_i$

(3) Non-relativistic Particles ($E \approx m + p^2/2m$):

- Number density: $n_i = g_i \left(\frac{m_i T}{2\pi}\right)^{3/2} e^{-m_i/T}$
- Energy density: $\rho_i = n_i m_i$
- Pressure: $P_i = n_i T$

THEORY

Number density, energy density, and pressure for particles with different thermal equilibrium distributions:

	Relativistic Fermions	Relativistic Bosons	Non-relativistic Particles (Fermions/ Bosons)
Number Density n_i	$\frac{3}{4}\frac{\zeta(3)}{\pi^2} g_i T^3$	$\frac{\zeta(3)}{\pi^2} g_i T^3$	$g_i \left(\frac{m_i T}{2\pi}\right)^{3/2} e^{-m_i/T}$
Energy Density ρ_i	$\frac{7}{8}\frac{\pi^2}{30} g_i T^4$	$\frac{\pi^2}{30} g_i T^4$	$n_i m_i$
Pressure P_i	$\frac{1}{3}\rho_i$	$\frac{1}{3}\rho_i$	$n_i T$

where $\zeta(3) \approx 1.202$ is the Riemann zeta function evaluated at 3.

We can see once the particles no longer relativistic, the number density and energy density will be exponentially suppressed.
It is because in the thermal plasma, the energy of particle are $E \sim T$, and when $T \ll 2m$, the probability of pair production which require energy $E \geq 2m$ will be very low, thus the number density and energy density will be suppressed.

Physics Intuition

It also explains why very few positrons exist in the current universe!
In the early universe, $T \gg m_e \approx 0.511\,\text{MeV}$, e^+e^- pairs were abundant.
As the universe cooled below $T \sim m_e$, the number density of positrons (and electrons) dropped exponentially, leaving only a tiny fraction that survived annihilation, which is why we observe so few positrons today.

Theory

We can see the relationship between p and ρ for different relativistic limits:

$$P = \begin{cases} \frac{1}{3}\rho & , T \gg m \\ nT \ll \rho & , T \ll m \end{cases}$$

In fact, it also consistent with the assumption of state parameter of radiation and matter, which are $w = 1/3$ and $w = 0$ when in relativistic and non-relativistic limits respectively.

Theory

The average particle energy is given by:

$$\langle E \rangle = \frac{\rho_i}{n_i} = \begin{cases} \frac{7\pi^4}{180\zeta(3)} T \approx 3.151T & , T \gg m \text{ for relativistic fermions} \\ \frac{\pi^4}{30\zeta(3)} T \approx 2.701T & , T \gg m \text{ for relativistic bosons} \\ m + \frac{3}{2}T & , T \ll m \text{ for non-relativistic particles} \end{cases}$$

Thats mean we can have a simplification of $\langle E \rangle \sim T$ for relativistic particles, as they have same order of magnitude, which is low enough error in astronomy :)

5.3 Effective Number of Relativistic DOF

Theory

The Friedmann equation shows that the expansion rate of the universe is determined by the total energy density ρ:

$$\rho(T) = \sum_i \rho_i(T)$$

where i runs over all particle species in the thermal plasma.

Considering in the the early universe, energy density is dominated by relativistic particles, we can directly sum over the relativistic species, and define the effective number of relativistic degrees of freedom g_* as:

$$\rho(T) = \frac{\pi^2}{30} g_*(T) T^4,$$

where:

$$g_*(T) = \sum_{\text{bosons}} g_i + \frac{7}{8} \sum_{\text{fermions}} g_i$$

Important Note

Note the above equation is only valid in early universe which radiation dominates. When universe cools down and matter dominates, the energy density will be dominated by non-relativistic particles, and above equation will no longer valid. In that case, we need to consider the contribution of non-relativistic particles to the energy density, which is given by $\rho_i = n_i m_i$.

REMARK

g_* is depends on T(i.e. $g_*(T)$), as the sum runs over only relativistic species, with $m_i \ll T$. As the universe cools down, more and more species become non-relativistic and drop out of the sum, thus g_* decreases with time.

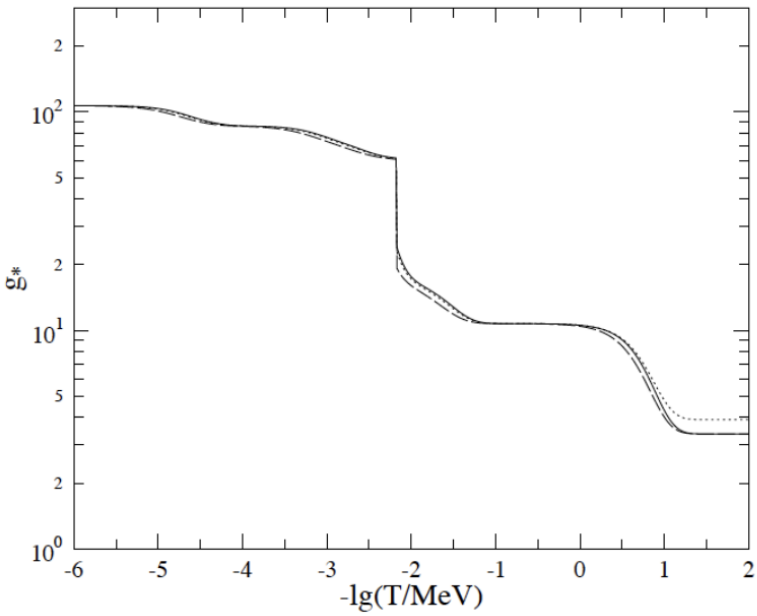

Figure 5.1: Evolution of g_* with temperature.

CHAPTER 6

Big Bang Nucleosynthesis (Lecture 13-14)

CHAPTER 7

Cosmic Microwave Background (Lecture 15-19)

CHAPTER 8

Dark Matter (Lecture 20-22)

CHAPTER 9

Inflation (Lecture 23-24)

CHAPTER A

Declaration of AI Assistance

A.1 Use of Artificial Intelligence in This Document

This course guide was developed with assistance from artificial intelligence (AI) in the following capacities:

- **Template Design:** AI provided guidance on structuring the document layout, choosing appropriate color schemes.
- **LaTeX Code Generation:** AI assisted in writing and refactoring LaTeX code, including package configurations, box styling (tcolorbox), TikZ decorations, and custom command definitions.
- **LaTeX Structure Refactoring:** AI helped reorganize and optimize the document structure for maintainability, readability, and professional presentation.
- **Mathematical Formula Formatting:** AI provided assistance in formatting and presenting mathematical equations in clear, readable notation aligned with conventions.

Author Verification: All content, including scientific accuracy, theoretical derivations, example problems, and pedagogical choices, has been carefully reviewed and verified by the author. The AI assistance was limited to technical formatting and structural optimization, not to the generation or validation of course content itself.

CHAPTER B

Mathematical Tools & Derivations

B.1 Useful Identities

Trigonometric

$$\sin^2\theta + \cos^2\theta = 1, \quad \tan\theta = \sin\theta/\cos\theta, \quad \sin(A \pm B) = \sin A\cos B \pm \cos A \sin B.$$

Hyperbolic

$$\cosh^2 x - \sinh^2 x = 1, \quad \sinh(x \pm y) = \sinh x \cosh y \pm \cosh x \sinh y.$$

Common Integrals

$$\int x^n\,dx = \tfrac{x^{n+1}}{n+1} + C \quad (n \neq -1), \qquad \int e^{ax}\,dx = \tfrac{1}{a}e^{ax} + C,$$

$$\int \frac{dx}{x} = \ln|x| + C, \qquad \int \sin x\,dx = -\cos x + C.$$

Taylor Expansions

$$f(x) = f(a) + f'(a)(x-a) + \tfrac{f''(a)}{2!}(x-a)^2 + \cdots$$

$$\sin x = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n x^{2n+1}}{(2n+1)!} = x - \tfrac{x^3}{3!} + \tfrac{x^5}{5!} - \cdots$$

$$\cos x = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n x^{2n}}{(2n)!} = 1 - \tfrac{x^2}{2!} + \tfrac{x^4}{4!} - \cdots$$

$$e^x = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{x^n}{n!} = 1 + x + \tfrac{x^2}{2!} + \cdots$$

$$\sqrt{1+x} = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \binom{1/2}{n} x^n = 1 + \tfrac{1}{2}x - \tfrac{1}{8}x^2 + \cdots$$

B.2 Differential Geometry Primer

The **metric tensor** $g_{\mu\nu}$ encodes the geometry of spacetime: $ds^2 = g_{\mu\nu}\, dx^\mu\, dx^\nu$. The **Christoffel symbols** (not tensors) are defined as

$$\Gamma^\lambda_{\mu\nu} = \tfrac{1}{2} g^{\lambda\sigma}(\partial_\mu g_{\nu\sigma} + \partial_\nu g_{\mu\sigma} - \partial_\sigma g_{\mu\nu}). \tag{B.1}$$

The **Ricci tensor** is the contraction $R_{\mu\nu} = R^\lambda{}_{\mu\lambda\nu}$ of the Riemann curvature tensor, and the Ricci scalar is $R = g^{\mu\nu} R_{\mu\nu}$. These enter the Einstein field equations as $G_{\mu\nu} \equiv R_{\mu\nu} - \frac{1}{2} g_{\mu\nu} R = (8\pi G/c^4) T_{\mu\nu}$.

CHAPTER C

Constants & Conversion Factors

C.1 Physical Constants

Quantity	Symbol	Value (SI)
Speed of light	c	$2.998 \times 10^{8}\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$
Gravitational constant	G	$6.674 \times 10^{-11}\,\mathrm{m^{3}\,kg^{-1}\,s^{-2}}$
Hubble constant today	H_0	$67.4 \pm 0.5\,\mathrm{km\,s^{-1}\,Mpc^{-1}}$
Cosmological constant	Λ	$1.11 \times 10^{-52}\,\mathrm{m^{-2}}$

C.2 Conversion Factors

Conversion	Value
1 astronomical unit (AU)	$1.496 \times 10^{11}\,\mathrm{m}$
1 light-year (ly)	$9.461 \times 10^{15}\,\mathrm{m}$
1 parsec (pc)	$3.086 \times 10^{16}\,\mathrm{m}$
1 parsec (pc)	$3.262\,\mathrm{ly}$
1 year (yr)	$3.156 \times 10^{7}\,\mathrm{s}$
1 eV	$1.602 \times 10^{-19}\,\mathrm{J}$
1 electron mass (m_e)	$0.511\,\mathrm{MeV}/c^2$
1 electron mass (m_e)	$9.109 \times 10^{-31}\,\mathrm{kg}$
1 proton mass (m_p)	$938.3\,\mathrm{MeV}/c^2$
1 proton mass (m_p)	$1.673 \times 10^{-27}\,\mathrm{kg}$
1 neutron mass (m_n)	$939.6\,\mathrm{MeV}/c^2$
1 neutron mass (m_n)	$1.675 \times 10^{-27}\,\mathrm{kg}$
1 Solar mass ($M_\odot$)	$1.989 \times 10^{30}\,\mathrm{kg}$
1 solar radius ($R_\odot$)	$6.957 \times 10^{8}\,\mathrm{m}$
1 Earth mass ($M_\oplus$)	$5.972 \times 10^{24}\,\mathrm{kg}$
1 Earth radius ($R_\oplus$)	$6.371 \times 10^{6}\,\mathrm{m}$

C.3 SI Unit Prefixes

Prefix	Name	Factor
10^{-9}	nano (n)	10^{-9}
10^{-6}	micro (μ)	10^{-6}
10^{-3}	milli (m)	10^{-3}
10^{3}	kilo (k)	10^{3}
10^{6}	mega (M)	10^{6}
10^{9}	giga (G)	10^{9}
10^{12}	tera (T)	10^{12}

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[1] Moshe Carmeli. "Value of the cosmological constant: Theory versus experiment". In: *AIP Conference Proceedings*. Vol. 586. AIP, 2001, pp. 316–318. DOI: 10.1063/1.1419571. URL: http://dx.doi.org/10.1063/1.1419571.